STUDIO HAMED OUATTARA

INSTITUTIONAL DOSSIER · PARCO THOMAS SANKARA, ROME

# SANKARA, L'ÉTERNEL VEILLEUR

A monumental Corten steel sculpture.
Statement of intent and presentation dossier.

Hamed Ouattara, multidisciplinary artist designer
Ouagadougou, 6 October 2026 — second edition

**English translation.** This document is the translation of the second edition of the French institutional dossier, Ouagadougou, 6 October 2026. In case of any divergence of interpretation, **the French original prevails**; it is available in the institutional area of the site.

## 1. Statement of intent

Burkina Faso has a national Memorial raised to the memory of Comrade President Thomas Sankara. This monument belongs to an approach that is complementary and distinct: to carry the memory of the President to the Burkinabè community settled in Europe, and to make it visible in an Italian public space used every day.

The work is given by Comrade Madi Sakandé, of the Burkinabè diaspora in Italy, to the benefit of the Burkinabè State, for the Parco Thomas Sankara in Rome.

This note sets out the design decisions that fall to me as the artist. The decision taken is that of a contemporary steel sculpture rather than a figurative statue. That choice answers three considerations.

The first is the nature of the place. It is an urban park people walk through, and not a dedicated memorial site. An upright work, plain and legible from every angle, belongs there better than a figure in the round, which presupposes a privileged viewpoint and a particular clearance.

The second is durability. Corten steel withstands European weather without maintenance, which guarantees that the work will last, with no maintenance falling to the local authorities.

The third is consistency with my practice. I have worked metal for more than twenty years, in a plastic language developed in Ouagadougou and recognised internationally. The monument is made in that hand, which makes it a Burkinabè work in full, and not a piece executed in a borrowed style.

### The treatment of the face

The portrait of Comrade President Thomas Sankara is fully identifiable. The military beret with its star, the gaze and the line of the face are rendered faithfully, and the work reads without hesitation,

from far off as from close to. The likeness chosen is the one the Burkinabè people know and recognise.

What is singular about it is how it is obtained. The face is neither painted nor engraved: it is cut clean through the plate. The dark areas of the portrait are voids straight through, the light areas are the steel left in place, and it is the contrast between metal and daylight that builds the figure, with the sharpness of a great stencil.

This method gives the portrait a changing presence. In the morning sun it stands out sharply, at noon it quietens, at dusk the half-darkness inside the monument gives it depth. The President is not fixed there in a pose: he is present differently at every hour of the day.

### The metal that does not give way

Corten steel has a rare property: it rusts at the surface, and that rust protects it instead of destroying it. It does not decay, it takes on a patina. Exposed to rain, to winters, to decades, it darkens, it settles, it holds.

No other material says better what there was to say. A just idea is not kept under glass; it stands out in the open, it takes the blows, and it is in taking them that it hardens. The colour of this metal is the colour of laterite, the red earth of our country. In Europe, the monument will carry the colour of Burkinabè soil.

### The skin of the metal, the work of the hands

The faces of the monument are covered with bosses, those half-spheres struck into the steel which for more than twenty years have been the language of my workshop. They come from the great Sudano-Sahelian earthen architectures, from Djenné, from Timbuktu, from Bobo-Dioulasso, from those thick bristling walls that breathe under a low light.

But they say something else as well. A boss is one blow. The plate has to be struck for it to appear. This regular grid is the count of repeated work, of the gesture begun again, of the collective effort that builds. It is the people around the man. The face is opened in the metal, but it is the struck metal that surrounds and holds it.

## 2. Reading the numbers

Nothing in this weave is left to chance. The numbers it carries come out of my research into the chronology of the Democratic and Popular Revolution and into 15 October 1987. I settled them before drawing the first line, and the geometry of the monument was built around them, within the constraints of proportion and fabrication that belong to steel plate.

| Element of the monument | What it counts |
|---|---|
| 12 rows on every face | The twelve companions who fell with him |
| 4 columns of bosses | 4 August 1983, the opening of the Revolution |
| 2 faces carrying the portrait | The two directions, north and south |

On 15 October 1987, Comrade President Thomas Sankara was assassinated in Ouagadougou with twelve of his companions. They rest today beside him in the Mausoleum. The monument carries twelve rows of bosses, on each of its four faces.

The four columns say 4 August 1983, the day the Democratic and Popular Revolution opened. The sculpture itself has four faces, and its face looks in two opposite directions, for the one arriving as much as for the one leaving.

The weave is the same on all four faces: forty-eight places, twelve rows of four. On the two faces that carry the portrait, twenty of those places are given back to the void — sixteen for the face, four for the name block. Twenty-eight remain. Where the metal has not been struck, that is him. The monument carries one hundred and fifty-two bosses in all.

> *These numbers come out of my research, and I settled them before I drew. A memorial sculpture that counted nothing would be mere ornament: this one had to carry a date and names, and the form was built around them.*

## 3. Description of the work

The monument is an upright rectangular prism in Corten steel, hollow, raised on a concrete base cast on site.

Two opposite faces carry the portrait of Comrade President Thomas Sankara, obtained by cutting clean through the plate in negative space, together with his full name and his dates. The two other faces carry no image: they are covered with the texture of bosses alone, a silence of matter that balances the force of the face.

Every face is worked in the same grid of hemispherical bosses standing proud. The artist's signature is cut into the steel, at the foot of one face, by the same technique as the portrait.

| Characteristic | Value |
|---|---|
| Form | Upright rectangular prism, hollow |
| Height | 200 cm, base excluded |
| Section | 70 × 70 cm |
| Material | Corten steel, 6 mm thick |
| Portrait | 2 opposite faces, cut clean through, in negative space |
| Texture | Hemispherical bosses, 139 mm across, standing 20 to 25 mm proud |
| Number of bosses | 48 per textured face, 28 per portrait face, 152 in all |
| Base | Reinforced concrete cast on site, stepped |
| Finish | Bare Corten, left to oxidise freely over time |
| Estimated weight | About 370 kg |

## 4. Siting and making

The work is destined for the Parco Thomas Sankara in Rome, Via Ugo della Seta, III Municipio, the only public space in Europe given over entirely to the memory of the President of Burkina Faso.

Fabrication is complete. The plates were worked in Italy by workshops equipped for laser cutting and for pressing the bosses. The assembly, the welding and the finishing were done by the artist in person in Bologna, and the steel has taken its first oxidation. Transport, the casting of the base and installation in Rome remain.

**The unveiling is set for Saturday 24 October 2026**, at the Parco Thomas Sankara.

### Public information device, as an option

It has been considered to set into the monument a QR code allowing the public to reach a note on the life and the work of Comrade President Thomas Sankara. The idea is a sound one, in particular for the Italian public and for younger generations, and I support it in principle.

I recommend, however, that this code should not be cut or engraved into the sculpture itself, but carried by a separate plate, set immediately beside the work.

Three reasons support this recommendation.

First, the nature of the object. A sculpture is a work, not a signage support. To introduce into its composition a functional element of a computing nature would alter how it is read and weaken the memorial force of the whole.

Next, permanence. A QR code points to an address online, whose life is measured in years. The monument, for its part, is designed to last decades. A code gone dead and engraved in steel would remain visible indefinitely, with no possibility of correction, whereas a plate is easily replaced.

Finally, legibility. The grid of bosses and the cutting of the portrait form a measured composition. Inserting a geometric motif foreign to that grid would break its balance and harm the reading of the face.

The separate plate, in matching Corten steel for visual unity, allows the integrity of the work to be kept while offering the public the information sought, and leaves the possibility of updating the content over time. This option remains open and can be studied with the authorities concerned.

### Why this concerns Burkina Faso

A monument installed abroad is not a work that moves away from the country, it is a work that carries it forward. It brings to Rome, into a public park Romans cross every day, the name and the face of an African head of State who refused debt, refused tutelage and defended the dignity of his people.

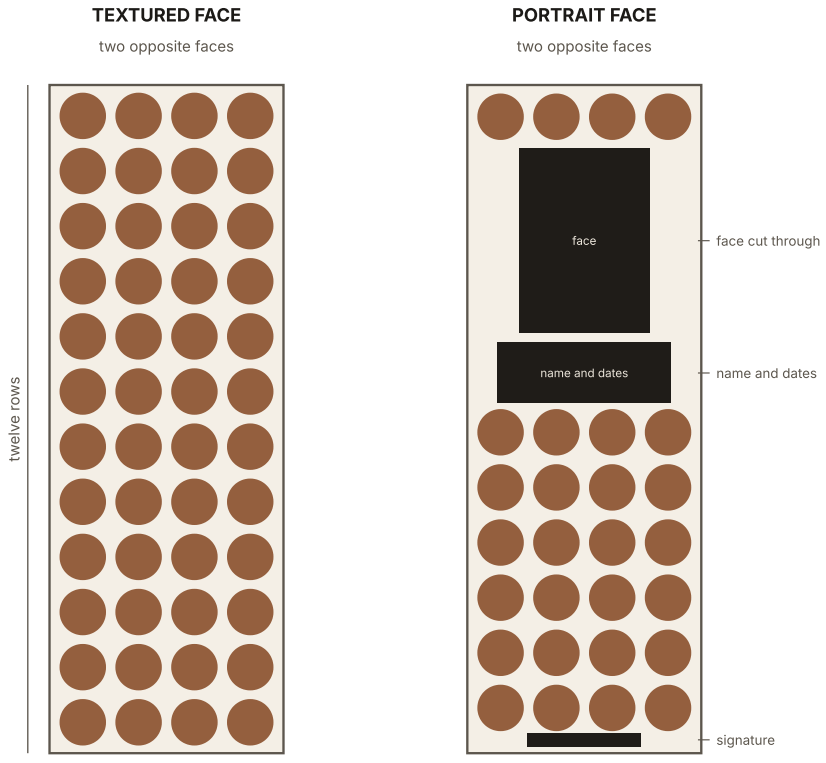
It is made by a Burkinabè artist, in a plastic language born in Ouagadougou, from a technique forged in a workshop on the Route du SIAO. What this monument exports is not a souvenir, it is a living skill, a living aesthetic and a living memory, produced in Burkina Faso and recognised abroad.

It is on that ground that I submit this dossier, for information and for adoption, to the Burkinabè authorities competent in matters of national memory and culture.

## 5. Illustrative drawing of the faces

The drawing below shows the two types of face of the monument. The portrait faces, two in number and opposite one another, carry the face, the name and the signature cut clean through the plate, with the side bands of the face left smooth. The two textured faces carry no cut and are covered with bosses over their whole height.

This document is illustrative. The dimensioned technical drawings, intended for the fabricating workshops, are available separately.




**2 textured faces + 2 portrait faces = 152 bosses**

## 6. The artist

Hamed Ouattara, whose civil name is Ouattara Mohamed Sékou, is a multidisciplinary artist designer, born in Ouagadougou. He founded the Studio Hamed Ouattara in 2002, a workshop organised as a guild with some fifteen craftsmen, on the Route du SIAO in Ouagadougou.

His practice rests on turning salvaged industrial metal into sculptural pieces that carry African memory and identity. His works are in the permanent collections of the V&A Museum in London, the Centre Pompidou in Paris, the Vitra Design Museum, the Brooklyn Museum in New York and the Denver Art Museum in Denver. He is represented exclusively by the Friedman Benda Gallery in New York.

He is a graduate of the École Nationale Supérieure de Création Industrielle in Paris, a Chevalier de l'Ordre du mérite des Arts since 2014, winner of the Africa Design Award in the same year, and president of the Association Art Contemporain du Burkina Faso.

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Done at Ouagadougou, 6 October 2026

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English translation. The handwritten signature appears on the French original.

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